on NCERT textbooks. The majority of state boards have adopted that syllabus and it is very similar to that of several others," says Prof. Kumar.

The third segment in CUET will be a general aptitude test, with questions on general knowledge, current affairs, general mental ability, numerical ability, quantitative reasoning (simple application of basic mathematical concepts—arithmetic/ algebra/ geometry/ mensuration/ statistics—taught till Grade 8), logical and analytical reasoning. Students will have to attempt at least 60 of 75 questions in this one-hour test. As per the NTA, this test will be "for any such undergraduate programme being offered by universities where a general test is being used for admission". Prof. Kumar says only those who plan to apply for vocational programmes or seek to change streams need to take this test. Some universities may additionally use the score in the aptitude test for admission in foreign language programmes.

"A university may accept candidates who have studied physics, chemistry and mathematics at the senior secondary level for admission to humanities and would consider the scores of the same subjects in the CUET domain test. Another university may simply ask for the general test scores. In such a case, candidates interested in both universities will take the domain tests for the subjects as well as the general test," says Vineet Joshi, director general, NTA.

Admissions will be done on the basis of the total CUET score along with some other criteria fixed by the respective universities. Although this will not affect the existing reservation quotas in admissions, the common test is expected to eliminate the impact of uneven scoring patterns across boards. For instance, there was a perception that the CBSE's liberal scoring methods gave its students an edge over those from state boards.

Not everyone is happy, though, with the change around the corner. Some say CUET will place an additional burden on students and aggravate their stress, with many of them also preparing for other entrance tests such as the IIT-JEE and NEET. Another worry is that students may ignore the 12th boards as its results would have little impact on college admissions. That apprehension may be somewhat misplaced as a university may fix a certain minimum score at the boards as a qualifying criterion. For example, a university may say that only those who have a minimum of 60 per cent marks in the boards are eligible to apply for admission using their CUET scores. Does that mean a university can decide on an eligibility cut-off of as high as, say, 98 per cent? "There will be no need for that," says Prof. Kumar. "Ultimately, the admission is based on the merit list derived from CUET scores. Even if a lower eligibility criterion such as 60 per cent is fixed, only the top few in the CUET merit list can get admission."

There is also a fear that the new entrance test on the block will be a godsent for the coaching industry, setting off a repeat of what seems to have happened in the case of engineering and medical tests. Will only those who can afford intensive coaching get to score high enough to join premier colleges? Prof. Kumar believes this fear is unfounded. "Coaching plays a role when students have to study a more extensive syllabus, with questions covering what is taught in both Class XI and Class XII. In CUET, however, the questions will be from the Class XII syllabus only, which anyway remains fresh in the minds of students," he says.



"It's mandatory for all central universities. We believe once they see merit in this test, state universities and deemed universities too will soon adopt this test for admissions"

PROF. M. JAGADESH KUMAR
Chairman, UGC



"The same flaws that exist in various school leaving examinations could creep into the common entrance test. It all depends on the quality of the test. If it has not been well-designed, it may fail to spot genuine ability and talent"

PROF. DINESH SINGH
Former Vice-chancellor, DU

Union education ministry officials also argue that there will be no need for coaching as the test will be an evaluation of aptitude. "As it's a computer-based test, we will regularly do data analytics and use the information to improve the test dynamics. There will be a constant effort to make it a level playing field for students from all backgrounds," says a ministry official.

Although he welcomes CUET "in principle", Prof. Dinesh Singh, a former DU vice chancellor, has cautioned against any "one-size-fits-all" test. "The same flaws that exist in various school leaving examinations could creep into the common entrance test. It all depends on the quality of the test. If it has not been well-designed, it may fail to spot genuine ability and talent," he says.

In fact, that seems to be the consensus among most educationists. While there is unanimity on the need for such a test—as prescribed by the New Education Policy—most experts are waiting to see how exactly it is designed. The fine print will determine whether the test can truly assess the abilities of students by offering a level playing field. ■